Hustle Hive CIC – Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy

Item	Detail
Organisation	Hustle Hive CIC, company no. 16691281
Version	4.0 (replaces version 3, July 2026)
Effective from	October 2026
Next review	September 2027, or sooner when Keeping Children Safe in Education or local procedures change
Approved by	Board of Directors

Version history

Version	Date	Author	Summary of changes
1	June 2026	Gavin Copland, DSL	Policy restructured to be simpler and more user friendly; definitions updated in line with Working Together to Safeguard Children and the Prevent duty guidance; summary table of safeguarding concerns and signs added; training table added
2	June 2026	Gavin Copland, DSL	Operation Encompass definition updated; contextual safeguarding examples added; overdose guidance added; procedure for children missing from home added

Version	Date	Author	Summary of changes
3	July 2026	Gavin Copland, DSL	Online harms, professional curiosity, child-on-child sexual violence and harassment, SEND, the four areas of online risk, mental health and elective home education updated in line with Keeping Children Safe in Education; sections added on learners questioning their gender and concerns about safeguarding practice
4.0	October 2026	Gavin Copland and Kieron Davis	Policy adapted to Hustle Hive CIC's structure as a two-Director alternative provision provider: new allegations route so that neither Director handles a concern about themselves; section added on learners placed by schools; classroom.cloud filtering and monitoring added; out-of-hours contacts added; school-specific references removed

Key safeguarding contacts

If a child is in immediate danger, call **999**.

Role	Name	Contact
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	Gavin Copland, Director	07593 975681, gavin@hustlehive.co.uk
Deputy DSL	Kieron Davis, Director	07395 828429, kieron@hustlehive.co.uk

Organisation	Contact
Darlington Children's Initial Advice Team (professionals reporting a concern)	01325 406252
Darlington Children's Front Door (public line)	01325 406222, childrensfrontdoor@darlington.gov.uk

Organisation	Contact
Out-of-hours emergency duty team	01642 524552 (weekday evenings from 5pm, 4:30pm Fridays, and 24 hours at weekends and bank holidays)
Darlington Designated Officer (LADO)	01325 405319, designatedofficer@darlington.gov.uk
Durham Constabulary (non-emergency)	101
Prevent (DfE counter-extremism helpline)	020 7340 7264, counter.extremism@education.gov.uk
Anti-Terrorist Hotline	0800 789 321
NSPCC Whistleblowing Advice Line	0800 028 0285
NSPCC FGM Helpline	0800 028 3550
Childline	0800 1111
Disclosure and Barring Service	03000 200 190
Teaching Regulation Agency	0207 593 5393

About Hustle Hive CIC

Our mission. Hustle Hive CIC empowers people of all ages through hands-on learning, enterprise and wellbeing. We provide alternative provision for young people, creative spaces for home-educating families, and skills, mentoring and resources for adults to launch businesses. By combining entrepreneurship, innovation and mindfulness, we help our community grow in confidence, resilience and opportunity.

Our vision. To create a vibrant community hub where enterprise, education and wellbeing connect, inspiring young people and adults alike to learn by doing, build their futures and thrive together.

Our values.

- **Inclusive community:** a fully inclusive community of aspiration, where a person's past decisions do not dictate their future opportunities.
- **Personalised support:** people of all ages and backgrounds have the right to a personalised offer that builds aspiration, entrepreneurship and physical and emotional resilience in a nurturing environment.
- **Hands-on learning:** the route to self-development is through real hands-on experiences where people create, build, test and grow.

1. Aims and scope

The welfare of the child is paramount. Hustle Hive CIC is committed to safeguarding and promoting the welfare of every child and young person who takes part in our activities, and safeguarding is everyone's responsibility.

We will:

- provide help as soon as problems emerge;
- protect children from harm and abuse, inside or outside the home and online;
- prevent harm to children's mental and physical health and development;
- make sure children grow up in circumstances consistent with safe and effective care; and
- act so that every child has the best possible outcomes.

This policy applies to all children and young people under 18 who attend our alternative provision, holiday clubs, Maker Days, workshops and other activities, on our premises, off site and online. It also applies to adults at risk who attend our courses. Everyone who works with us must follow it: directors, staff, volunteers, students on placement, contractors and visitors.

We follow *Keeping Children Safe in Education* (current edition), *Working Together to Safeguard Children*, the *Prevent duty guidance* and the procedures and thresholds of the Darlington Safeguarding Partnership.

2. Our ethos

Many of the young people we work with are more vulnerable than their peers. They may have been excluded or disengaged from school, have special educational needs, be known to children's social care, or have experienced trauma. We keep this in mind at all times.

- **It could happen here.** Staff stay alert and use professional curiosity: they notice, ask and follow up rather than assume.
- **Children are listened to.** We create an environment where young people feel safe to talk and know they will be taken seriously.
- **No secrets.** Staff never promise to keep a secret, and explain what will happen to anything a child tells them.
- **Act early.** We share concerns early so children get the right help at the right time.
- **Work together.** We work openly with parents, carers, commissioning schools and other agencies. We usually discuss concerns with parents and carers, unless doing so could put a child at greater risk.

- **Teach safety.** Through our sessions we help young people understand risk, healthy relationships, online safety and how to get help.

3. Roles and responsibilities

Board of Directors

The Directors are responsible for making sure that:

- this policy and related procedures meet statutory guidance and are reviewed every year;
- a trained DSL and deputy DSL are in place, and one of them is always available during sessions, in person or by phone;
- any allegation about either Director is passed by the other Director to the LADO within 24 hours, so no one handles a concern about themselves;
- safer recruitment is followed and the Single Central Record is kept up to date;
- all staff receive safeguarding training at induction and every year;
- filtering and monitoring on our devices is in place and reviewed every year; and
- the Board receives a safeguarding report from the DSL every term and an annual report.

The Directors also check that safeguarding is working in practice. They carry out safeguarding visits during the year, check the Single Central Record every term, review all low-level concerns and the actions taken, arrange an external review of our safeguarding arrangements from time to time, and make sure staff feel able to raise concerns about poor or unsafe practice. Our sessions help learners understand what is safe and unsafe, and support critical thinking and safe decision-making.

Designated Safeguarding Lead (Gavin Copland)

The DSL has lead responsibility for safeguarding and child protection, in line with Annex C of *Keeping Children Safe in Education*. The DSL:

- is the first point of contact for staff with any safeguarding concern;
- decides what action to take, makes referrals to children's social care, the police, Channel (Prevent) and the DBS, and records the reasons for every decision;
- keeps safeguarding records secure and separate from other learner records;
- shares safeguarding information promptly with commissioning schools and other agencies;
- attends, or makes sure someone attends, child protection conferences, core groups and strategy meetings;

- leads staff safeguarding induction and updates;
- understands and oversees online filtering and monitoring; and
- makes sure parents and carers know this policy is available on our website.

The deputy DSL (Kieron Davis) is trained to the same level and covers all DSL duties when the DSL is unavailable.

The DSL will also:

- give advice and support to other staff on child welfare and child protection matters, and quality assure their records;
- make sure every member of staff, volunteer and regular visitor receives safeguarding information during induction, and deliver that first part of induction;
- liaise with the Darlington Safeguarding Partnership and other agencies, and be trained to contribute to child protection conferences, strategy discussions and other multi-agency meetings;
- share information with the commissioning school about the issues a learner, including a learner with a social worker, is experiencing, so that their education can be supported;
- know that any child who is arrested or interviewed by the police must have an **appropriate adult**. The DSL or deputy will liaise with parents or carers to arrange this, and make sure they understand that Hustle Hive CIC staff cannot act as the appropriate adult for a learner suspected of a crime; and
- seek advice from the Children's Initial Advice Team or the LADO for complex concerns where the next steps are unclear.

If, in exceptional circumstances, the DSL is not on site, they or the deputy DSL will always be available by phone.

All staff and volunteers

Everyone working with us must read and follow this policy and Part 1 of *Keeping Children Safe in Education*, report every concern to the DSL straight away, follow our code of conduct and never investigate a concern themselves.

4. Training

Who	Training	How often
All staff and volunteers	Safeguarding induction, including this policy, KCSIE Part 1, the code of conduct, online safety, filtering and monitoring, low-level concerns and whistleblowing	On starting
All staff and volunteers	Safeguarding and child protection training, including Prevent	Every year, plus regular updates
DSL and deputy DSL	Designated Safeguarding Lead training	Every 2 years, with knowledge updated at least every year
Directors	Safeguarding training suitable for their role	On appointment and every year
Anyone on an interview panel	Safer recruitment training	Every 3 years

Training is recorded on our training matrix.

Induction

When new staff or volunteers join us, they are told about our safeguarding arrangements during induction. They receive a copy of this policy, our staff code of conduct and Part 1 of *Keeping Children Safe in Education*, and are told who the DSL and deputy DSL are. Induction covers the signs of abuse, how to respond to a disclosure, how to record and report concerns, the role of the DSL, whistleblowing, and what a low-level concern is and how to report one. Everyone is expected to read these documents and understand their responsibilities.

Keeping up to date

The DSL and deputy DSL update their knowledge and skills at regular intervals, and at least every year, in addition to their formal training every two years. Throughout the year, the DSL briefs staff on key safeguarding issues, changes to *Keeping Children Safe in Education* and local risks. We encourage all staff to keep up to date with local and national safeguarding guidance.

5. Responding to concerns

Signs to look out for

Staff should report any concern, however small. Common signs include a change in a child's behaviour or presentation, unexplained injuries or explanations that don't fit, signs of neglect, worrying comments, drawings or play, poor or irregular attendance, going missing, unexplained money or gifts, new older friends, and anything a child, parent or other person tells us. Children may not feel ready to tell anyone, or may not recognise what is happening to them as harmful, so staff must stay curious.

Staff must report straight away:

- any injury, mark or bruise that is not easily explained by the normal knocks and scrapes of everyday activity;
- any explanation that seems inconsistent or suspicious;
- any behaviour that suggests a child may have been harmed, such as worrying drawings, play or actions;
- any concern that a child is not being properly cared for, or is being ill-treated or emotionally harmed;
- any significant change in a child's presentation, including not attending;
- any hint or disclosure of abuse, from anyone; and
- any concern about a person who may pose a risk to children, for example someone living in a household with children.

Staff should think especially carefully about children who may be more vulnerable to abuse, such as children with special educational needs, children with a history of abuse or neglect, children who are often absent, and children living with domestic abuse.

If a child tells you something

Staff will:

- stay calm, listen and take what the child says seriously;
- let them speak freely, and only ask open questions such as "Can you tell me what happened?";
- never promise to keep it a secret, and explain that they must tell the DSL to keep the child safe;
- not ask leading questions, investigate or confront anyone;
- reassure the child that they have done the right thing and tell them what will happen next; and
- write down what the child said, in their own words, as soon as possible.

Staff will also try not to show shock or disbelief, will not express feelings or judgements about anyone the child says has harmed them, and will explain that only the people who need to know will be told. Where possible, the child should not have to repeat their account to another member of staff. A disclosure may not be a single event, and a child may share more later. Information from parents, carers or members of the public is treated in the same way.

Reporting

1. **If a child is in immediate danger,** call 999, then tell the DSL.
2. **Tell the DSL straight away,** or the deputy DSL if the DSL is unavailable. Do not wait until the end of the session.
3. **Record the concern the same day** on our cause for concern form, signed and dated. The form is printed on coloured paper so it stands out. Blank forms are kept securely at the Hustle Hive premises and in every portable first aid kit. Include what you saw or heard, the child's exact words, the date and time, who was present and what you did. Use the body map on the cause for concern form to show where any marks are, but never examine a child or take photographs of injuries.
4. **The DSL decides what to do next,** including whether to seek advice or refer to the Children's Initial Advice Team, the police or the commissioning school, and records the decision and the reasons for it.
5. **Follow up.** If you do not think the child's situation is improving, raise it again with the DSL. If you are still worried, speak to a Director or contact the Children's Initial Advice Team yourself.

Anyone can make a referral. If the DSL and deputy DSL cannot be reached and a child may be at risk, staff contact the Children's Initial Advice Team or the police directly, then tell the DSL as soon as possible.

Family help

Where a child or family would benefit from early support, the DSL will discuss this with the family and the commissioning school, and may contribute to or start a family help assessment in line with the Darlington Safeguarding Partnership's thresholds. If things do not improve or get worse, the DSL will consider a referral to children's social care.

6. Specific safeguarding issues

Abuse and neglect rarely happen in isolation, and issues often overlap. Staff report all concerns to the DSL, whatever category they seem to fit.

Type	What it means	Examples of signs (not a complete list)
Physical abuse	Deliberately hurting a child, such as hitting, slapping, shaking or throwing	Unexplained or repeated injuries, marks or burns; covering injuries even in hot weather; unable to recall how an injury happened; aggressive or withdrawn
Emotional abuse	Persistent emotional ill-treatment, such as making a child feel worthless, unloved or afraid	Low self-esteem; constant self-criticism ("I'm stupid", "I'm worthless"); anxiety; extreme behaviour; self-harm; fear of going home
Sexual abuse	Forcing or enticing a child into sexual activity. It can be contact abuse or non-contact abuse, such as showing sexual images or persuading a child to perform sexual acts online	Sexualised language or behaviour beyond their age; pain, itching or bruising in the genital area; secrecy; sudden changes in behaviour around a particular person
Neglect	Persistent failure to meet a child's basic needs	Persistent hunger or tiredness; poor hygiene; unsuitable or dirty clothing; untreated medical problems; poor attendance; parental substance misuse
Domestic abuse	Controlling, coercive, threatening or violent behaviour between people who are or have been partners or family members. Children may see, hear or experience it	Fear of leaving a parent; anxiety; withdrawal; tiredness; a parent with injuries; a parent or child anxious to please the other parent

Type	What it means	Examples of signs (not a complete list)
So-called honour-based abuse	Crimes committed to protect the perceived honour of a family or community, including female genital mutilation, forced marriage and breast ironing. Often involves several family or community members	Sudden decline in motivation or aspirations; excessive restrictions at home; not allowed to attend activities; always accompanied to and from sessions
Female genital mutilation	Procedures that deliberately alter or injure the female genital organs for non-medical reasons	Long absence or a long trip abroad; changes in behaviour on return; bladder or menstrual problems; difficulty sitting still; pain between the legs; mentioning something they are not allowed to talk about
Radicalisation and extremism	The process of a person coming to support terrorism or extremist ideologies, including non-violent extremism and divisive narratives that can be linked to terrorism (for example incel subculture)	Possessing extremist material; sympathy for extremist causes; glorifying violence against other groups; extremist graffiti, art or writing; changes in attendance; rejection by peers or family
Children absent from education	Prolonged or repeated absence, which can be a warning sign of abuse, neglect, exploitation, mental health problems or a risk of forced marriage or FGM	Unexplained absence; patterns of absence; going missing during the day
Homelessness	Lacking stable housing, or being at risk of losing it, for example because of debt, rent arrears, domestic abuse or eviction	Poor attendance; arriving hungry or tired; staying with friends or relatives; withdrawn or aggressive

Type	What it means	Examples of signs (not a complete list)
Young carers	Children who give significant unpaid care or emotional support to a family member with a disability, illness or substance misuse problem	Lateness; absence; tiredness; social isolation; withdrawn
Self-harm	Deliberately harming one's own body	Wearing long sleeves or trousers to hide marks; cuts, burns or bruises; hair pulling; withdrawal
Extra-familial harm	Significant harm outside the family and home, sometimes called contextual safeguarding, including exploitation and serious violence	Gang association; isolation from usual friends; going missing or returning home late; returning under the influence of drugs or alcohol
Child criminal exploitation	An individual or group using an imbalance of power to coerce, control or manipulate a child under 18 into crime, in person or online	Unexplained money, clothes or phones; links with older people or gangs; seen in cars that don't belong to family; drugs or drug equipment
Child sexual exploitation	An individual or group using an imbalance of power to coerce, control or manipulate a child under 18 into sexual activity, in person or online	Links with older people or gangs; gifts; self-harm or big changes in emotional wellbeing; seen in unfamiliar cars
County lines	Gangs and criminal networks using children to move and sell drugs, often across areas, which can involve criminal and sexual exploitation, modern slavery and trafficking. The DSL can ask a social worker or the police to complete a National Referral Mechanism referral for a possible victim of exploitation	Receiving requests for drugs by phone; moving drugs or money; concealing drugs internally; being found in places they have no connection with (such as a "trap house")

Type	What it means	Examples of signs (not a complete list)
Child financial exploitation	Using a child's bank account to move money from crime, sometimes called "money muling"	Secretive use of phones; unusual questions about banking; being blocked from their bank account; withdrawn
Child trafficking and modern slavery	Children tricked, forced or persuaded to leave home, moved and then exploited, forced to work or sold	Doing excessive household work; rarely leaving the house; living apart from family; poor living conditions; unsure where they are
Serious violence	Offences from common assault to murder, including the use of knives, firearms or acid	New friendships with older people; decline in performance; disrupted education; signs of assault or unexplained injuries; links to weapons
Harmful sexual behaviour	Sexual behaviour by children or young people that is developmentally inappropriate, harmful or abusive	Trying to coerce others into sexual activity; intrusive behaviour; misuse of power; sexual violence
Online harms, misinformation and misogyny	Online content or contact that damages safety or wellbeing, including misinformation, conspiracy theories and extreme misogyny, which is linked to sexual harassment and harmful sexual behaviour	Sudden extreme or irrational views; hostility to gender equality; mocking women in authority; using "manosphere" language such as "incel", "alpha/beta/sigma" or "red pill"; increased screen time; mistrust of authority

Staff should also be alert to:

- **abuse in intimate personal relationships between young people** (sometimes called teenage relationship abuse), including controlling or coercive behaviour, which can happen face to face and online;
- **grooming**, where someone builds a relationship, trust and emotional connection with a child so they can manipulate, exploit or abuse them, in person or online;
- **upskirting**, taking a picture under someone's clothing without their permission, which is a criminal offence under the Voyeurism (Offences) Act 2019; and

- **sextortion** (financially motivated sexual extortion), where a young person is tricked or pressured into sharing nude images and then blackmailed for money or more images. Learners are told it is never their fault and to tell a trusted adult straight away, without paying or deleting the messages.

Child-on-child abuse

Children can abuse other children, including through bullying, physical violence, sexual violence and harassment, initiation or hazing, and sharing images without consent. We never dismiss this as "banter" or "part of growing up". All reports are taken seriously and passed to the DSL, who will support everyone involved, including the child who has caused harm, and refer to social care or the police where needed.

To reduce the risk of child-on-child abuse, we:

- make sure staff know the signs and how to respond;
- address inappropriate behaviour, even if it seems minor;
- make sure learners know our behaviour and online safety expectations;
- supervise learners closely, especially during less structured times and in less visible areas;
- take steps to prevent isolation, and separate learners where needed; and
- put an individual safety plan in place where a risk is identified.

Learners know who they can talk to, and can use the Report a Concern button on our laptops.

When an incident is reported:

- it is recorded on a cause for concern form;
- the DSL speaks to each learner involved separately;
- where another school or setting is involved, the DSL shares information with its DSL;
- the DSL balances the child's wishes against the duty to protect them and others, and may need to refer to children's social care or the police against the child's wishes. If so, this is explained sensitively and support is offered; and
- parents and carers are told, unless this would put a child at greater risk.

Everyone involved, including the child who has caused harm, is supported. Support is tailored to each child, the victim is never made to feel they are the problem for reporting, wherever possible they can keep to their normal routine, and we do all we reasonably can to protect the anonymity of any children involved in a report of sexual violence or harassment.

Sexual violence and sexual harassment

We follow Part 5 of *Keeping Children Safe in Education*. Sexual violence and sexual harassment are never acceptable and are never passed off as "banter", "just having a laugh" or "boys being boys". We recognise that even when there are no reports, it may still be happening, and that misogyny can escalate. We challenge behaviour such as grabbing, lifting clothing or sexualised comments straight away, because tolerating it can normalise it. When a report is made, we immediately consider how best to support and protect the victim, the alleged perpetrator and any other children affected.

Online safety and sharing nudes

We teach learners about the four areas of online risk:

- **content:** being exposed to illegal, inappropriate or harmful material, such as pornography, racism, misogyny, self-harm and suicide content, radicalisation, extreme violence, misinformation, disinformation and conspiracy theories;
- **contact:** harmful online interaction with others, including grooming, peer pressure, commercial advertising, and adults pretending to be children;
- **conduct:** online behaviour that increases the chance of harm, such as sending or receiving explicit images, sharing other people's personal information, and online bullying; and
- **commerce:** risks such as online gambling, inappropriate advertising, phishing and financial scams.

Learners agree to our acceptable use rules before using our devices.

Filtering and monitoring with classroom.cloud

All learner laptops are managed through classroom.cloud (by NetSupport), our classroom management and online safety platform. We use it to meet the Department for Education's filtering and monitoring standards on our devices. It allows us to:

- **control websites:** block harmful or inappropriate sites, and restrict learners to approved sites during activities;
- **see what learners are doing:** staff can view learners' screens live during sessions and step in straight away;
- **flag concerning words and phrases:** classroom.cloud checks what learners type and search for against a database of more than 20,000 words and phrases, including slang. These cover risks such as self-harm and suicide, bullying, sexual and criminal exploitation, radicalisation, drugs and violence, and we can add our own terms. A match creates an alert, with a screenshot, for the DSL;

- **let learners report a concern:** learners can use the Report a Concern button to tell a trusted member of staff about a worry privately, which helps young people who find it hard to speak up face to face; and
- **signpost help:** learners can find details of support organisations, such as Childline, from their device.

Monitoring only takes place on Hustle Hive CIC devices during sessions. Gavin Copland, as DSL, receives all alerts and learner reports. Kieron Davis covers this when Gavin is unavailable. Alerts and reports are reviewed the same day and handled like any other safeguarding concern: recorded, acted on and shared with the commissioning school or other agencies where needed. Staff also watch screens during sessions and report anything worrying straight away.

The DSL checks that filtering, monitoring and alerts are working every term, including a test search. The Directors review the system every year, or sooner if something goes wrong or our needs change. Parents and carers are told about monitoring when their child joins us, and the details are on our website.

Sharing nudes and semi-nudes

If staff learn that nude or semi-nude images of a child are being shared, they must not view, copy, forward or delete them. They confiscate the device if it is safe to do so, switch it off and give it to the DSL. The DSL follows national guidance for education settings on responding to sharing nudes and semi-nudes, including when to involve the police.

Creating or sharing nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18 is illegal, even when it is consensual or the image is AI-generated, so incidents need careful handling.

Do	Do not
Tell the DSL or deputy straight away	View, copy, print, share, download or move the image
Explain to the learners involved that you need to tell the DSL	Delete the image or ask a learner to delete it
Secure the device if it is safe to do so	Ask the learner to tell you what the image shows
Record what you were told, not what you saw	Share information about the incident with anyone except the DSL

The DSL holds an initial review to decide whether there is an immediate risk, whether to refer to the police or children's social care, what further information is needed, and whether parents and carers should be told (in most cases they will be). **An immediate**

referral to the police or children's social care is made if:

- an adult is involved;
- a child may have been coerced, blackmailed or groomed, or there are concerns about their capacity to consent;
- the images show sexual acts that are unusual for the child's development, or are violent;
- the images show sexual acts and any child in them is under 13; or
- a child is at immediate risk of harm, for example presenting as suicidal or self-harming.

Images are only ever viewed in exceptional circumstances, on the DSL's decision, with another Director present and a record made of why. We signpost learners to Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation's Report Remove tool, support the child without blame, and help parents and carers understand what has happened and where to get support. If a learner may be being groomed or sexually exploited online, we also report it to NCA-CEOP.

If a device needs to be passed to the police, it is confiscated, disconnected from Wi-Fi and data, and turned off straight away so that nothing can be deleted remotely. Where the DSL decides, after the initial review, that no referral to the police or children's social care is needed, learners are usually asked to delete the images and confirm they have done so. Staff never ask a learner to do this before the DSL has reviewed the incident. Children can be involved in sharing nudes in different ways, and may feel scared, embarrassed or angry. We listen to their concerns, take them seriously, and keep them informed about what will happen next.

Cybercrime

Some learners with a strong interest in computing may stray, deliberately or not, into cybercrime such as hacking. If staff are concerned, the DSL considers a referral to the Cyber Choices programme, which helps young people use their skills legally.

Radicalisation and extremism (Prevent)

Staff report any concern that a young person may be at risk of radicalisation to the DSL, who will seek advice and, where appropriate, refer to Channel. If there is an immediate threat, call 999 or the Anti-Terrorist Hotline.

We treat protecting learners from radicalisation like any other safeguarding risk. We make sure that:

- staff, volunteers and Directors understand what radicalisation and extremism are, why to be vigilant and how to respond;
- filtering and monitoring on our devices protect learners from extremist material;

- the DSL has completed Prevent training and is our point of contact for these concerns;
- the DSL keeps a Prevent risk assessment of local risks up to date; and
- our sessions promote respect, tolerance, democracy and the rule of law, helping learners build resilience and critical thinking.

All staff help reduce "permissive environments" by challenging extremist narratives and content. Channel is a voluntary, confidential programme that supports people at an early stage who are susceptible to being drawn into terrorism. Prevent referrals may be discussed at a multi-agency Channel panel, and the DSL attends where needed.

Female genital mutilation

Any staff member who is a qualified teacher and discovers that female genital mutilation appears to have been carried out on a girl under 18 must report it to the police personally, by calling 101, and also tell the DSL. All other staff tell the DSL straight away.

Mental health and self-harm

Mental health problems can be a sign that a child has suffered or is at risk of abuse, neglect or exploitation. Staff report concerns to the DSL. If a learner says they have taken an overdose or are at immediate risk, staff call 999, stay with the learner and inform the DSL and the parent or carer.

Only trained professionals should diagnose a mental health problem, but staff see learners every day and are well placed to notice changes. Our role is to promote good mental wellbeing, spot early signs that a learner may be struggling, make sure support is in place quickly, and work with the commissioning school, parents and specialist services. Where a learner has no diagnosis, staff describe what they see rather than using the language of diagnosis.

If a learner says they have taken an overdose or harmed themselves, staff tell the DSL and a first aider straight away. If possible, find out calmly what was taken and when, but do not delay calling 999. Where there is an ongoing concern about a learner's safety because of their mental health or self-harm, the DSL puts a safety plan in place with the learner, their family and the school. If a learner needs urgent help that is not an emergency, staff can use NHS 111.

Children with special educational needs or disabilities

Children with SEND may face additional barriers to telling someone about abuse, and signs may wrongly be put down to their needs. Staff take extra care to notice and report concerns, and use the communication methods that suit each child.

Additional barriers can include:

- assuming that signs of abuse, such as behaviour, mood or injury, are caused by the child's disability without looking further;
- children with SEND being affected more by things like bullying, without showing obvious signs;
- communication barriers; and
- difficulty telling the difference between fact and fiction online, and repeating harmful content or behaviour.

The DSL works closely with the commissioning school and SEND professionals when deciding how to support a learner with SEND.

Children in care, care leavers and children with a social worker

The DSL makes sure staff know which learners have a social worker, are looked after, or were previously looked after (for example, adopted or under a special guardianship order), so they can support them appropriately. The DSL works closely with their social worker and the virtual school head, who also supports previously looked-after children.

Lesbian, gay, bisexual and trans learners

Being lesbian, gay, bisexual or trans is not in itself a risk factor for harm, but these young people can be targeted by other children and may face extra barriers to telling someone. We make sure every learner has a trusted adult to talk to, challenge homophobic, biphobic and transphobic language and behaviour straight away, and treat any related bullying or harassment as a safeguarding concern where appropriate.

Children with a family member in prison

Children with a parent or close family member in prison are at greater risk of poor outcomes, poverty, stigma and mental health problems. Where we know about this, the DSL makes sure staff can offer sensitive support, and can signpost the family to organisations such as Children Heard and Seen or the National Information Centre on Children of Offenders.

Child abduction and community safety

Child abduction is the unauthorised removal or keeping of a child from a parent or anyone with legal responsibility for them, and can be committed by parents, other family members, people known to the child or strangers. Staff only release learners to adults named on the registration form, and report any concern about a stranger approaching

learners, or any incident in the local community, to the DSL and, where needed, the police. Through our sessions, learners are helped to think about how to stay safe when out and about.

Private fostering

If we learn that a child under 16 (or under 18 if disabled) is living for 28 days or more with someone who is not a parent or close relative, the DSL tells Darlington children's services.

Local context

The DSL keeps up to date with the risks young people face in Darlington, using information from the Darlington Safeguarding Partnership, Durham Constabulary and commissioning schools. These include risks such as criminal exploitation and county lines, anti-social behaviour, online harms and the influence of older peers. We use this information in our sessions, our learners' individual risk assessments and our staff training, and review it every year.

Children missing from home or care

If staff learn that a child is missing from home or care, they tell the DSL straight away, who will contact the police and the parent, carer or social worker.

7. Learners placed by schools and the local authority

Learners in our alternative provision remain on their school's roll. Their school or local authority keeps overall responsibility for their education and safeguarding, and we work closely with them.

Before a placement starts

We ask the commissioning school to share all relevant safeguarding information before the learner starts, through a secure method. This includes any child protection or child in need plan, the name of any social worker, known risks, medical needs and an emergency contact list. The DSL reviews this information and completes the learner's individual risk assessment before their first session. If we have not received enough information to keep the learner and others safe, the placement does not start until we have.

Attendance and children absent from education

We take a register at the start of every session and tell the commissioning school about any absence by 10:00am (within 30 minutes of the session starting), in line with our Attendance and Absence Procedure and the placement agreement. If a learner does not

arrive and we have not been told why, we contact the parent or carer and the school straight away. Repeated or unexplained absence can be a sign of abuse, neglect or exploitation, so the DSL reviews attendance concerns with the school. If a learner leaves without permission, we follow the missing-learner procedure in our Health & Safety Policy.

Sharing information

We tell the commissioning school's DSL about any safeguarding concern about a placed learner on the same day, alongside any referral we make. When a placement ends, we securely pass relevant safeguarding records back to the school.

Elective home education

For home-educated children attending our Maker Days and other activities, we follow this policy in full. If we have concerns about a home-educated child, the DSL contacts the parent or carer where appropriate and refers to Darlington children's services where there is a safeguarding concern.

8. Safer working practice

All staff follow our staff code of conduct, which sets out the professional boundaries expected when working with young people. In particular:

- **Recruitment.** Everyone working with learners is recruited and checked in line with our Safer Recruitment policy.
- **Contact and communication.** Staff do not contact learners through personal phones or social media. Messages go through approved Hustle Hive CIC accounts and, for children, to parents or carers unless agreed otherwise. Staff do not give learners personal contact details.
- **One-to-one work.** One-to-one mentoring takes place in a visible space, such as a room with the door open or a vision panel, with another adult aware it is happening.
- **Transport.** Staff only transport learners with written parental consent, in an insured and roadworthy vehicle, and with the journey agreed in advance. Where possible, two adults travel. When a single member of staff must drive a learner alone, a Director must agree it in advance, the learner sits in the back, and the driver tells a colleague when they set off and arrive. Any incident or unplanned stop is recorded.
- **Photos and video.** Photographs and video of learners are only taken on Hustle Hive CIC devices, with consent from the parent or carer (and the learner where appropriate), and are only used as agreed. Staff never take images of learners on personal devices.

- **Gifts and favouritism.** Staff do not give or accept personal gifts beyond small tokens, or show favouritism.
- **Physical contact.** Physical contact is kept to what is appropriate and necessary, in line with our Behaviour policy.

Use of reasonable force. Staff use de-escalation and positive behaviour support first, in line with our Behaviour and Positive Conduct Policy. Reasonable force is only ever used as a last resort, for the shortest possible time and with the minimum force needed, to stop a learner hurting themselves or others or causing serious damage. Any use of force is recorded and reported to the DSL, the parent or carer and the commissioning school on the same day, and the learner's individual risk assessment is reviewed.

Visitors and contractors

All visitors sign in, wear a visitor badge and are told who the DSL is. Visitors who have not been checked are supervised at all times and never left alone with learners. Visiting speakers and workshop providers are checked in advance, and we review any material they plan to use. A session is stopped if a visitor's behaviour or content is inappropriate.

Where appropriate, visitors are asked to confirm they have a suitable DBS check and to show photo ID when they arrive, and we keep a record of all visitors. Visitors are expected to respect the values of democracy, the rule of law, individual liberty, and mutual respect and tolerance of different faiths and beliefs.

9. Allegations and concerns about adults

We follow Part 4 of *Keeping Children Safe in Education* and Darlington's procedures for managing allegations. An allegation is any information suggesting that someone working with children has:

- harmed a child, or may have harmed a child;
- possibly committed a criminal offence against or related to a child;
- behaved towards a child in a way that suggests they may pose a risk of harm to children; or
- behaved in a way that suggests they may not be suitable to work with children.

Who to report to

Both staff members who deliver sessions are Directors, so we use the route below to make sure no one investigates themselves.

Allegation about	Report to
A volunteer, contractor, visitor or member of staff who is not a Director	The DSL (or deputy DSL), who contacts the LADO within 24 hours
Gavin Copland (DSL)	Kieron Davis, who contacts the LADO within 24 hours
Kieron Davis (deputy DSL)	Gavin Copland, who contacts the LADO within 24 hours
Either Director, if you are unsure or uncomfortable reporting internally	The LADO directly, on 01325 405319

The person receiving the allegation does not investigate, interview the child or the adult, or tell the adult concerned until the LADO has advised. If a child is at immediate risk, call 999.

Low-level concerns

A low-level concern is any concern about an adult's behaviour towards children, however small, that does not meet the threshold for an allegation but does not fit our code of conduct. Examples include being over-friendly with a learner, having favourites, contacting learners outside sessions, taking photos on a personal phone or using inappropriate language. Staff record low-level concerns on our low-level concern form and pass them to the DSL, or to the other Director if the concern is about Gavin Copland or Kieron Davis. If you are uncomfortable doing this, contact the LADO for advice. Concerns are kept confidential and reviewed for patterns. Staff are also encouraged to report their own behaviour if they think it could be misinterpreted.

Whistleblowing

Anyone who is worried about poor or unsafe practice should raise it under our Whistleblowing policy. If they feel unable to raise it internally, they can contact the NSPCC Whistleblowing Advice Line on 0800 028 0285.

Referral to the DBS

Where we remove someone from working with children, or would have done had they not left, because they have harmed or posed a risk of harm to a child, we will make a referral to the DBS, as the law requires. If the person is a qualified teacher, we will also consider a referral to the Teaching Regulation Agency.

10. Records and information sharing

The DSL keeps a separate, confidential safeguarding file for each child with a concern. Paper records are kept in a locked cabinet, and digital records in a secure, access-controlled system. We plan to move to CPOMS, and until then all concerns are recorded on paper cause for concern forms and stored securely by the DSL. Each record includes the concern in the child's own words where possible, the actions taken, the decisions made and the reasons for them, and who completed it.

Data protection law does not stop us sharing information to keep children safe. Fears about sharing information must never get in the way of protecting a child. Information is shared on a need-to-know basis, and the DSL records what was shared, with whom and why. When a learner moves on, their safeguarding file is passed securely to their next setting or back to the commissioning school.

11. Working with parents and carers

Parents and carers are told about this policy when their child joins us, and it is published on our website. We will usually discuss concerns with them, unless doing so could put the child at greater risk or affect a police or social care investigation. Parents and carers must give us at least two emergency contacts and tell us about any changes, including who has parental responsibility and any court orders. Anyone who has a concern about a child, or about a member of staff, can speak to the DSL or contact the Children's Front Door.

To keep children safe, parents and carers must give us accurate, up-to-date details of:

- all adults the child normally lives with;
- everyone with parental responsibility, if different;
- emergency contacts; and
- any other adult allowed to collect the child.

We only share information about a child with adults who have parental responsibility, unless there is a safeguarding reason not to. We treat parents and carers with respect and honesty. A lack of parental agreement with our concerns will not stop us acting to protect a child.

We will support and contribute to child protection conferences, core groups and other multi-agency meetings, sharing reports in advance where requested.

Child protection conferences

Children's services hold a child protection conference when an enquiry under section 47 of the Children Act 1989 finds that a child is at continuing risk of significant harm. The DSL, or another trained member of staff, represents Hustle Hive CIC at conferences and

core group meetings. Reports are prepared in advance using the local authority's template, checked by the DSL, and shared with parents and carers before the meeting where appropriate. We work openly and honestly with parents and carers whose child is subject to a child protection plan.

12. Learners questioning their gender

Some learners may question their gender identity. The welfare of the child is paramount, and we will provide an environment where all learners are treated with dignity and respect. Hustle Hive CIC does not start any steps towards social transition. This section applies only where a learner or parent has asked for support.

When a request is made, we follow a documented process:

- **Parents and carers.** Parents and carers have the leading role in their children's lives. We involve them as a priority and take their views seriously.
- **The DSL.** In the rare cases where involving parents would put the learner at greater risk, the DSL is involved straight away to decide what to do before any further step is taken.
- **Best interests.** We consider what is in the best interests of the learner and other learners, which may not always match the learner's wishes.
- **The commissioning school.** For placed learners, we work with the school so our approach is consistent.

Decisions are made case by case by the Directors and the DSL, in line with current Department for Education guidance, safeguarding law, the Equality Act 2010 and the Human Rights Act 1998, and the reasons are recorded. We explain these limits sensitively:

- learners use toilets and any changing facilities for their biological sex, or a self-contained alternative where we can provide one;
- on any overnight trips, learners do not share sleeping accommodation with learners of the opposite biological sex; and
- records show a learner's biological sex accurately.

The DSL reviews decisions regularly, especially if new safeguarding concerns arise, and is involved where a learner is "living in stealth" because of the particular vulnerabilities this can bring. We support any learner who wishes to reverse a previous request, working with their parents and relevant experts. Bullying or harassment of a learner questioning their gender is never tolerated.

13. Concerns about our safeguarding practice

If anyone is unhappy with how we have handled a safeguarding concern, they should raise it with the DSL. If the concern is about the DSL, they should raise it with Kieron Davis, or seek advice from the LADO or the NSPCC Whistleblowing Advice Line. Allegations about adults follow section 9.

14. Legal framework

Human rights

Our safeguarding practice draws on the Human Rights Act 1998, in particular:

- Article 3: the right to freedom from inhuman and degrading treatment;
- Article 8: the right to respect for private and family life, which includes protecting a person's physical and psychological integrity;
- Article 14: the right to enjoy these rights without discrimination; and
- Protocol 1, Article 2: the right to education.

Harassment, violence or abuse, including of a sexual nature, may breach any of these rights.

Equality

This policy follows the Equality Act 2010. We do not discriminate against any learner because of their sex, race, disability, religion or belief, gender reassignment, pregnancy and maternity, or sexual orientation, and we make reasonable adjustments for disabled learners.

Legislation and guidance

This policy is written in line with:

- Keeping Children Safe in Education (Department for Education, current edition);
- Working Together to Safeguard Children (current edition);
- Darlington Safeguarding Partnership procedures;
- What to do if you're worried a child is being abused (DfE);
- Information sharing: advice for practitioners (DfE);
- Prevent duty guidance (Home Office);
- Mandatory reporting of female genital mutilation: procedural information (Home Office);

- the Children Act 1989 and 2004, the Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act 2026, the Human Rights Act 1998 and the Equality Act 2010;
- Sharing nudes and semi-nudes: advice for education settings (UK Council for Internet Safety);
- Meeting digital and technology standards in schools and colleges, including filtering and monitoring (DfE);
- SEND code of practice: 0 to 25 years (DfE);
- Supporting pupils with medical conditions (DfE);
- Working together to improve school attendance (DfE);
- Promoting and supporting mental health and wellbeing in schools and colleges (DfE); and
- Non-school alternative provision: voluntary national standards (DfE).

15. Monitoring and review

The DSL reports to the Board every term on safeguarding activity, training, the Single Central Record and any lessons learned. This policy is reviewed every year, and sooner after a serious case or when *Keeping Children Safe in Education* or local procedures change.

Related policies

Read this policy alongside our Safer Recruitment, Behaviour and Positive Conduct, Online Safety and Media, Whistleblowing, Health & Safety, Medical Needs and Medicines, Data Protection and Records Retention policies, and our staff code of conduct.

Forms

We use a safeguarding induction checklist, a cause for concern form with a body map, and a low-level concern form.

Approval and signatures

This policy has been approved by the Board of Directors of Hustle Hive CIC.

Name	Position	Signature	Date
Gavin Copland	Director and DSL		
Kieron Davis	Director and deputy DSL		

Name	Position	Signature	Date
Carey Viala	Director		
Sarah Smith	Director		

Appendix: Safeguarding induction sheet

For new staff, volunteers, students on placement and regular visitors. Read this before working with learners and sign below.

We have a legal duty to safeguard and promote the welfare of children, and at Hustle Hive CIC we take this seriously.

- **If you are worried about a child,** tell the DSL or deputy DSL straight away. No worry is too small: we would rather know about something that seems minor than miss something serious.
- **If you think the matter is serious,** such as possible physical, emotional or sexual abuse or neglect, find the DSL or deputy straight away and complete a cause for concern form the same day.
- **If a child is in immediate danger,** call 999, then tell the DSL.
- **If a child tells you something,** listen, don't promise to keep it secret, don't ask leading questions, and write down what they said in their own words.
- **If you are worried about an adult's behaviour,** tell the DSL. If it is about Gavin Copland or Kieron Davis, tell the other Director. You can always contact the LADO directly on 01325 405319.

Role	Name	Contact
Designated Safeguarding Lead	Gavin Copland	07593 975681
Deputy DSL	Kieron Davis	07395 828429

I have read and understood this induction sheet and know who to go to with a concern.

Name	Role	Signature	Date